

The Transition

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Of course, his family had heard of the operation, knew not only that such a thing was possible but that there were actually people doing it, and although his family was conservative, his family wasn't radical by any means, in fact his family was really quite moderate, so much so that during elections in which the conservative candidate seemed especially intolerant or corrupt or feeble-minded his family was occasionally even known to vote for the liberal alternative, and although his family was religious, his family certainly wasn't the type to speak of issues in terms of good and evil, and for instance had no qualms about nudity in the media, and sometimes drank to excess, and wasn't opposed to gambling, and believed in evolution, and although his family was poor, not destitute exactly, but decidedly working class, and held no college degrees, his family possessed no prejudice against people who elected to have vanity surgeries like liposuction and rhinoplasty, and were always heartened to meet people benefiting from bionic modifications such as pacemakers and prostheses, and enjoyed watching programs of an educational nature, and took naturally to new technologies—and yet there was something that set the operation apart from other issues, something that repulsed his family almost instinctually, something that filled his family with contempt, a fact his family had made no effort to hide, like back when the news had been flooded with stories about a famous architect who had transitioned and his family had spent an evening sitting around out on the stoop ridiculing the architect, or

back when the news had been flooded with stories about a former model who had transitioned and his family had spent an evening sitting around out on the stoop bashing the model, and so the fact that his family found the concept utterly loathsome certainly would have been clear to Mason.

Then there was also his personality. He was profoundly reserved. He rarely smiled. He seldom laughed. He spoke clearly, without any animation. Although he often complained, he never became angry. He never seemed gloomy. He never appeared excited. He must have cried occasionally as a child, but no incidents came to mind specifically, and regardless he certainly hadn't cried in the presence of his family since. He never showed signs of feeling powerful emotions.

So, considering that he was showing signs as he sat there at the table, that his hands were trembling, that his voice was shaking, that he was so nervous that the feeling was actually affecting him physically, and that he really wasn't in the habit of joking about this type of thing—or, quite honestly, joking about anything—there seemed to be no doubt that he was serious when he interrupted a moment of silence to announce, or rather confess, that he was planning to have his mind converted to digital data and transferred from his body to a computer server.

Mason's father, who was wearing his favorite apron, with the cartoon pelican across the chest and the maroon stain just beneath the pockets, gaped at him from the counter in the kitchen, frozen there in the midst of dipping a silicone spatula into a container of the latest batch of his secret sauce. Mason's brothers, who planned to drive the motorboat down to parkland at dusk to go shrimping on the bayou, were reclined around the table in athletic jerseys and camouflage cutoffs, squinting at him with expressions of confusion. Mason's mother had come in from the backyard when she had heard him arrive, wearing the straw hat and baggy caftan that she'd been sunning in, and she felt such a jolt of panic when he

said what he said that she had to set her iced tea down onto the nearest surface, the stove, or else she surely would have dropped the bottle onto the floor.

Mason stared at the table, and then, as if suddenly daring to hope that the idea might be met with no resistance, looked up and blurted, “We’ll still be able to talk or whatever.”

His mother crossed the kitchen toward the table, feeling past the counter with her hands, her eyes never leaving him. He must have been coming from a shift at the supermarket. His uniform was rumpled. His nametag was askew. He’d always been scrawny, but recently he seemed especially frail. His eyebrows were so light in color that he didn’t seem to have eyebrows at all, which had caused him untold trouble on the playground as a child. He had watery eyes, a delicate nose, thin lips, and a weak chin. He looked like the type of person who’d probably have a milk allergy. She couldn’t explain what that was supposed to mean exactly. A neighbor had said it about him once though, and as soon as she’d heard it, she’d known it was true. She loved his face. As she slid into a chair at the table, she had to resist an urge to reach over and cup his jaw in her palms. The thought of losing him was terrifying.

“I mean, I’ll be able to chat whenever you want, I’ll be online literally all of the time,” Mason said, gaze falling back to the table.

His mother turned toward the counter, searching for some indication of how his father was reacting to the announcement. The heat from the sun was already leaving her skin, and the sensation seemed almost like a manifestation of her fear, as if the emotion were sapping the warmth from her skin as the feeling spread. She had been relaxing in a canvas lawn chair all morning, sipping from that bottle of iced tea, watching with amusement as sparrows hopped along the branches of the tree, basking in the occasional gust of wind that rushed across the backyard, letting loose tremendous yawns, stretching her limbs out, rubbing her eyes with the heels of her hands, scratching her belly periodically when the

urge struck, savoring the tart aroma of the charcoal burning in the grill, enjoyably conscious of being dressed in a bright caftan and floppy hat. Coming in from that realm of bodily pleasure to be confronted with somebody who wanted to leave all of that behind was intensely jarring. She didn't understand what he could be thinking.

Over by the counter his father set down the spatula.

"You do realize that not having a body would mean not having a body?" his father said.

"Yes."

"As in never again?" his father said.

"Yes."

"What the hell is wrong with your head?" his father said.

His father swore only when he was deeply afraid, which told his mother that she wasn't the only one taking the announcement seriously. Despite how grave the situation was, however, his father apparently really did need to check on the grill before the ribs burned. Scowling, with the hem of his apron flapping at his shins with every step, his father marched out the door into the backyard.

Mason, who had been staring intently at his knuckles during that brief exchange with his father, glanced back up again. His cheeks were flushed; sweat pitted his shirt. His mother suddenly felt sure that this discussion, albeit awkward, would be easily resolved. Years from now, his family was going to look back on this moment and laugh about his mistake, like how the family still joked about the time that one of his brothers had considered quitting his job in order to sell dietary supplements for a company from door to door until the family had explained to him that the operation was obviously a scam, or how the family still joked about the time that one of his brothers had considered starting a jazz group until the family had explained to him that yes he might love the drums but honestly he had no rhythm and he didn't belong anywhere near a stage. Certainty spread through

her, and a bit of pride that she had been the one to realize that this was all a misunderstanding. She felt so relieved that she had to suppress a grin.

“You’re just not thinking,” she announced.

“About what,” Mason said.

“I don’t know what put the idea in your head, but you’re not like those other people doing it, there’s too much you’d miss about having a body,” she said.

She could tell from his stare that she hadn’t yet convinced him, and she folded her hands together, searching for an example.

“Like dancing,” she exclaimed.

“I hate dancing,” Mason said.

“Oh you do not,” she said, and then she fell silent, because she knew of course that he did.

Until now his brothers had been sitting back observing the scene, picking their teeth, biting their nails, but his brothers finally exploded.

“What the heck bro?”

“Where did this even come from?”

“How could you actually want something that messed up done?”

“Our own flesh and blood?”

His oldest brother leaned in.

“You’d even give up sex?” his oldest brother said.

Mason didn’t reply, just gazed at the centerpiece, a vase of wildflowers.

“What about sex?” his oldest brother demanded.

Mason gave a faint shrug.

“More trouble than it’s worth,” Mason said.

She had never seen his brothers look so offended.

His oldest brother sat back, knitting his fingers behind his head with his elbows thrown wide in a posture of dismissal, and sneered, “Well, who cares if you want it done, you’ll never have enough money to pay for it.”

“I already do,” Mason said.

Mason apparently had been setting aside a substantial portion of each paycheck for years now. His mother fiddled with the bangles around her wrists in distress. Back when his family had sat around mocking the celebrity chef who’d transitioned, back when his family had sat around trashing the piano prodigy who’d transitioned, he must have been saving up money for the operation even then. He had sat there and had listened to his family call people like that monsters and had secretly believed that he was a person like that all along. The thought stunned her.

Mason stared at the table, then glanced back up with a desperate look, exclaiming, “I hate having to deal with clothing. I hate having to go shopping and trying to find things that fit and having to put together an outfit every single day and worrying about what matches and having to drag everything down to the laundromat. I hate getting sick. I hate getting headaches and getting backaches and getting earaches and getting toothaches and puking especially. I hate having to get checkups at the doctor and the dentist and the optometrist every single year. I hate always having to make meals and eat the food and wash dishes afterward. I hate having to shower. I hate having to sleep. I’m tired of wasting so much of my life on taking care of a body. I just want to be able to read stuff and talk to people all of the time.”

“Sweetie,” his mother said. She leaned across the table, her heart beating frantically, and laid her hands over his hands. “I know you might feel like that right now, but if you’d just stop and think about it for a couple days, you’re going to change your mind.”

“I’ve been thinking about it for over twenty years,” Mason said.

He eased his hands out from under her hands, pulling away, as if ashamed.

“I don’t belong in a body,” Mason said.

He lowered his head.

“I’ve always known,” Mason said.

He left before the meal was served, slipping out the door with his shoulders slumped, then sputtering off down the road in his rusty hatchback. While his brothers sat around the table bitterly rehashing that comment about sex, his mother drifted in a daze out into the backyard, where his father was squatting over the grill. Looking up from the ribs with an expression of fury, his father confessed that he had come out to the backyard not so much out of concern for the ribs as out of fear that he had been about to cry, which he had never done in the presence of the children before and didn’t want to.

Mason had scheduled the operation for later that month, taking the earliest available appointment the local clinic could offer. As his mother brushed her teeth that night, an activity in which she usually found much enjoyment—the tingle of foam on her tongue, the prick of bristles against her gums—she couldn’t focus on the experience at all, but instead was gripped by a feeling of dread. She had driven past the local clinic before, a nondescript facility with screened windows and tinted doors, and the place always seemed to have a sinister aura. Although he had asked his family to be there for the operation, there was no way that she could go. She found the concept disturbing enough when the procedure was done to a stranger, let alone her youngest son. What frightened her most was imagining the actual transition. The exact moment when his body would be empty. The exact moment when his mind would be gone.

She had never suspected he might want something like that, but now that she knew he did, she couldn’t help feeling like she should have suspected all along. He had always been different than his brothers. He had been a puny, feeble, pallid child. Even back then he had

whined about everything. He hadn't liked doing puzzles. He hadn't liked making crafts. As an eater he had been picky, declining to eat fruits, refusing to eat vegetables, not even liking candy, subsisting mainly on cereal and macaroni. He'd sipped reluctantly at colas. He'd grudgingly nibbled at cookies. His brothers in contrast had eaten with gusto, devouring multiple helpings apiece of whatever she'd cooked, praising the flavors in exultation, licking salt from lips and grease from fingers. His brothers had been playful too, wrestling each other and racing each other and spinning each other dizzy and taking great joy in both resisting and surrendering to gravity, climbing trees and leaping from roofs and soaring and plunging back and forth on swings, but he'd had an aversion to physical activity. He hadn't even liked walking. He'd had a listless gait, walking about with his arms limp and his feet dragging, as if having to walk was an arduous task, simply onerous. Getting him to make the walk from the front door of the house to the bus stop at the corner on weekday mornings had been nothing short of a miracle. He hadn't liked going outdoors at all. If she had tried to take him bicycling, he would crank at the pedals a few times, then grumble, gradually coast to a stop, slide off of the seat, let the bicycle fall onto the pavement, and flop down on the curb, refusing to go any farther, complaining that pedaling made his legs hurt. If she had tried to take him canoeing, he would heave on the paddle a few times, then mutter, slump over on the seat, and stare at the bottom of the canoe, complaining that paddling made his arms hurt. If she had tried to take him swimming at the ocean, the water had always been too hot or too cold or too salty or too wet. While his family had tossed a foam ball around in the shallows, he had sat on the beach with his arms wrapped around his shins and his chin propped on his knees, either in the sun, complaining that the light was too bright, or under the umbrella, complaining that the shade was too dark. Sitting on the sand had made his butt hurt.

He was remarkably annoying. Yet despite how finicky he was—or maybe even be-

cause—he had always been her favorite. She adored him. As a child the only time he had ever seemed content was when he had been left to his own devices. He had preferred to stay indoors, hunched over a screen on his beanbag in his bedroom, poring through on-line encyclopedias. Compared to how reserved he had been in person, he had seemed to come alive when exchanging messages with people over the internet. Occasionally she had even heard him chuckle or snicker in there at something he had read. She had taken pains to keep him from being disturbed.

Now she couldn't help blaming herself for what was happening. She had only wanted him to be happy, but in the process she had ruined him. She should have forced him to play with other children. She should have forced him to eat whatever she had cooked instead of letting him prepare meals of bland grains. She should have forced him to bike and she should have forced him to canoe and she should have forced him to swim until he had learned how to love the world. It was her fault that he had ended up like this. She had failed him as a mother.

She spit toothpaste into the sink, rinsed the toothbrush under the faucet, shut off the lamp in the kitchen, set an alarm for work the next day, and then climbed into bed. His father was lying there on his back with the blanket thrown off. Moonlight coming through the window illuminated the strip of gut exposed between the band of his briefs and the hem of his tee. She stared at the silhouette of the fan on the ceiling for a while.

"I reject the notion that somebody can be born that way," his father grumbled.

She felt the mattress dip as he shifted to look at her.

"If you're born in a body, then you belong in a body, and that's that," his father said.

When she didn't respond he swiveled back toward the ceiling.

"He's just lazy. Doesn't want to work anymore. Just wants to live for free. God knows we've got enough of those types in this country. Well, okay, he's paying for it himself. So

maybe he'll be more like somebody who's retired than like some freeloader on welfare. Fine. But you can't turn somebody into data. They can turn his memories to data, they can turn his beliefs to data, they can turn his knowledge to data, and his particular mannerisms, and his thought patterns, and his exact vocabulary, but even if they put all of that stuff into the computer, there's still going to be something missing. I'll tell you this much, those things in the computers don't have souls. Because you can't turn that to numbers. You just can't. And for the record, he could have at least stayed for supper," his father exclaimed.

And she knew he needed to rant, so she let him rant. And later, she stuck her face into her pillow and wept so violently that the bed shook, and he knew she needed to weep, so he let her weep. And then for the rest of the night she alternated between fidgeting and lying as still as possible, too upset to sleep.

From then on that became her norm, both at night and during the day, just constant worrying. Even when she wasn't thinking about it she was thinking about it. No matter where she was at, no matter what she was doing, whether she was searching through the envelope of coupons in her purse to pay for tampons at the pharmacy or she was concentrating on the descriptions of the various deductions that her accountant recommended making before filing taxes, an awareness of the situation was always there in the background of her other thoughts, interrupting. I am losing my son. I am losing my son. I am losing my son.

Since graduating, Mason had been renting a house with some roommates, who no doubt would claim his belongings after the operation. But there wouldn't be much to claim. His furnishings were spare, just a bed with a sheet, stacked crates with folded clothes, a battered plastic hamper, dirty bowls on the windowsill containing flecks of dried milk and crusted cheese, a framed photo of his family on the wall, the tangled cords of his

chargers on the floor, and his beanbag. She had been over there a number of times, once to bring him chicken broth when he had the flu, once to bring him emergency funds after he had been mugged. The roommates that he'd found were strange—women with glazed looks who played video games excessively, shifty men who were always busy mailing and receiving mysterious packages and constantly reeked of curry and patchouli, aggressively chatty people who believed that the moon landings had been a total hoax and that astrological systems were indisputably factual—and she had worried about him living there. That his roommates might pressure him into doing something risky, like heroin, or orgies. Activities so pleasurable that the activities were addicting. And there had in fact appeared to be cause for concern. He had seemed unwell in recent years. Not just because of how frail he had become, but the bags that had formed in the skin beneath his eyes, and the furrow that had formed in the skin between his eyebrows. She had wondered if he was depressed.

After confessing his plan to his family, however, Mason immediately seemed to improve. In the coming weeks he occasionally drove over in the evening to hang out on the stoop with his family, sitting there in his regular chair with his usual slouch as if everything were normal. Sipping from a bottle of iced tea, his mother would study the changes in his appearance from across the stoop. The bags beneath his eyes had faded. The furrow between his eyebrows had disappeared. Some of the color had actually returned to his skin. In fact, the nearer the day of the operation came, the healthier he seemed, and that alarmed her more than the symptoms of depression ever had, because his growing excitement seemed like proof that he genuinely believed he needed the operation.

She set her bottle of iced tea down onto the stoop, then shifted in her chair to turn toward the street, returning a wave to a neighbor in a passing car. She had always assumed that once hormones hit he would finally become interested in the lively social network at

school, but even as a teenager he had preferred digital interactions to relationships in person. His brothers had been daredevils in those years, exploring abandoned factories with friends, egging the vehicles of enemies, roaming around heckling tourists for fun, constantly coming and going from the house with every departure and arrival announced by the thwack of the screen door and stomps on the front steps, but he had been as much of a homebody as ever. He had dated a few people—the longest had been a timid mathlete with a strand of hair dyed aquamarine—and the romances had at the very least been earnest sexually. Sorting through his dirty laundry, his mother had occasionally discovered a sock stiff with dried semen; dumping the contents of his trash can into the garbage container in the garage, his mother had sometimes spotted a condom wrapper in with the mix. Yet he had never seemed truly enamored with anybody, speaking of the people he dated with the same reluctant preference he showed for cereal and macaroni, as if sex were merely another appetite to be sated. And otherwise he hadn't shown much interest in his schoolmates at all. For the sake of convention she had wished that he would join some extracurriculars, maybe try out for a musical or run for student council, but for selfish reasons she also had been glad that he had spent most weekends hunched over a screen in his bedroom. She had loved having him nearby, just getting to glance at him as she walked past the room to fetch a sponge from the kitchen, or getting to dust the mirror in the bathroom knowing that he occupied a room just down the hall. Stopping to visit him between chores, she would see apps flashing across his screen at an almost blurry rate as he switched between chats and forums and the comments beneath articles. She had marveled at how many conversations he could engage in simultaneously.

"What are you talking about on there?" she had asked him once, standing over his beanbag with a vacuum cradled in her arms.

"Everything," Mason had said, drawing out the syllables of the word for emphasis.

And he had in fact seemed to be interested in everything, occasionally sharing at supper what he had learned throughout the day, the topics ranging from subjects like oceanography and astrophysics to bits of gossip about mods and other friends from online. Puberty had added a lump to his throat that dipped when he spoke. His scalp had shed dandruff that his mother was forever having to brush from the back of his shirt, and though she had insisted that he and his brothers be asleep by midnight during the schoolweek, on the occasions when she had risen in wee hours to use the bathroom and while padding down the hall had spotted the faint glow of a screen shining through the crack below his door, she had never asked him to go to bed. She had taken any chance to accommodate him, even when that had required breaking her own rules.

Thinking of that, she actually could remember a time he had cried. When he was a teenager a particularly catastrophic hurricane had blown through, and though the house had been spared any significant damage, the power had been out for weeks afterward, with no way to get online. His brothers had always thrived during outages, enjoying the novelty of eating canned goods by the light of a gas lantern and flushing the toilet with water stored in plastic milk cartons, and had treated those weeks like an extended camping trip, lounging around the living room spooking each other with urban legends and playing board games that hadn't been pulled from the closet in years. Mason, however, had struggled. The longest the power had ever been out before was a few days at a time, and he must have assumed that would be the case again, because he had spent the first few days after the storm sitting on the windowsill in the living room with his arms folded across his chest, watching the street with an intent expression, as if utility trucks from the electric company were due to arrive at any moment. As the outage had dragged on, his bearing had gone from impatient to agitated, with a set clench to his jaw and his lips pursed tight, and he had behaved increasingly anxious, replying to questions with dis-

tracted grunts, ignoring requests to join activities, just pacing around the window in the living room kicking at the carpet, or for hours sometimes simply slumping across his beanbag with a blank screen clutched in his hands, until finally one morning after waking up to discover that the power still hadn't been restored, he had broken down weeping at breakfast, burying his face in his arms, with the descending knobs of his spine protruding through the stretched fabric of his shirt as he sobbed. His brothers had stared at him with mild shock.

"The power has to come back on eventually," his mother had said, trying to reason with him from across the table.

But he had been inconsolable, his body trembling in frustration.

"This is the worst thing that's ever happened to me," Mason had cried.

At the time, she had dismissed the statement as a bout of melodrama, just another complaint from a child prone to complaining, but now she realized that he may have meant what he had said: that the worst he had ever felt was being cut off that long from the internet.

Her name was Hailey, but she was a mother—even before giving birth to the boys, she had always felt that was what she was meant to do, her identity—and his mother especially. She loved his father, she loved his brothers, yet the family hadn't felt complete to her until he had come along. When she had first held him, a bleary newborn with a wisp of pale hair, she had been struck by that exact thought. This is everybody. And she still felt that way, sitting around on the stoop, like the family wasn't complete without him. He balanced out everybody else, that gawky figure over by the railing. She loved how he would set his ballcap in his lap to fuss with the snaps on the plastic adjuster for a while absentmindedly. She loved how he would tuck his hands into the webbed cupholders attached to his chair as if the holes had been included for that exact purpose. She loved

how when she accidentally bumped the bottle of iced tea by her feet while laughing at his brothers, he lunged to catch the wobbling bottle before the iced tea could spill. When she slipped indoors to blow her nose, the gentle lilt of his voice drifting in through the screen door gave her a sense of well-being. When she returned outdoors with a file for her nails, the sharp odor of the sneakers he had kicked off by the front steps made her swell with contentment. He had a presence she could feel even when she wasn't looking. And now all of that was tinged with dread. She knew what the stoop was like when he wasn't there, from days he was at work, or days he was home sick. On those days there was an empty space. An absence over by the railing that she was constantly aware of, no matter how hard she tried to be happy with what she had. And after the operation, that empty space would be there forever, the rest of her life.

His family avoided talking about the operation around him without exception. His father, who had never understood him but had always made an effort to understand him anyway, had given up, maintaining a polite yet firm silence on the matter, as if acknowledging the choice might count as consent. His brothers, who had defended him from any accusations of weirdness when he was younger with a ferocity that had sent critics running, now just sat back looking embarrassed if the issue was mentioned, as if too humiliated to speak. His mother, who in truth usually couldn't resist a topic that promised a bit of drama, was struck dumb with fear when given the opportunity to join a discussion about the decision. Even Mason himself avoided the subject. Although he may have been relieved to have confessed his plan, he was obviously still ashamed of his plan too. Whenever anybody brought up the operation, his hands would tremble and his voice would shake, the same as when he had made the initial announcement. And the operation came up often when he was on the stoop. By now word of his plan had spread through the neighborhood. He was a spectacle, like somebody out on bail for a crime that would mean

life in prison, a local landmark about to vanish from the neighborhood forever in a sensational fashion. Neighbors would wander over to the stoop under the pretense of talking with his family, chatting about basketball or landscaping or potholes or the weather until enough time had passed to be able to turn to him casually to ask about the operation, as if the subject had only just then come to mind.

In general the neighbors seemed less interested in hearing his perspective than in reporting what they personally felt was so worthwhile about having a body and then explaining that he actually liked having a body just as much as they did. He would tug uncomfortably at the collar of his tee while a neighbor expounded on the wonders of bubble baths; he would fidget uneasily with the rips in his jeans while a neighbor testified to the greatness of scented lotion. And his mother thought that he did seem to give serious consideration to what the neighbors said. Yet whatever the neighbors insisted would be worth keeping a body for, he always responded that he would still prefer to live as data. He wouldn't miss driving with the windows down. He wouldn't miss wearing slippers, dressing up for weddings, or changing out of wet clothing into dry pajamas. He wouldn't miss jambalaya, peanut butter, mustard on pretzels, burritos bursting with cheese and beans and salsa bundled up in wrappers, pepperoni pizza with the crust flavored subtly like cardboard from the box, lobster so tender that the meat flaked apart, the maraschino cherry off the crown of a banana split, the extra portion of milkshake in the steel cup that always felt like a surprise bonus after you had finished the serving in the glass, pancakes drenched in maple syrup and waffles dolloped with whipped cream, bacon dripping with so much grease that the oil had soaked the paper towel underneath, popcorn coated with so much salt that a layer of crystal had formed at the bottom of the bucket, chili dogs heaped with onions and seasoned with the smell of cut grass at a ballpark, buffalo wings slathered with cayenne and seasoned with the smell of lit candles at a pub, toasted

marshmallows oozing out from between slabs of chocolate and graham cracker with the scent of campfire on your fingers, toffee so buttery you had to wipe your lips afterward, fudge so rich you would feel your toes curl involuntarily, the tang of a bite of pickle with the peppery aftertaste of a pastrami sandwich still fresh on your tongue, hot fries with cold ketchup, chocolate chip cookie dough, fried green tomatoes, pecan pie, grits, or beignets. He wouldn't miss getting buzzed on coffee, wine, or cigarettes. He wouldn't miss the shiver of ecstasy after scratching a mosquito bite. He wouldn't miss roller coasters. He wouldn't miss wave pools. He wouldn't miss turnstile gates. He wouldn't miss funnel cakes. He wouldn't miss souvenir hats. He wouldn't miss anything about amusement parks whatsoever. He wouldn't miss the rush of adrenaline after running a stoplight, the almost giddy relief following a bout of hiccups, sucking drinks through straws, having caricatures drawn, feeling drowsy, collapsing into a mound of blankets and pillows, naps so intense you woke up drooling, the sound of rain, the smell of rain, or wind chimes.

"It's unnatural," a neighbor grimaced, speaking of the operation, which was the closest that any of the neighbors ever came to condemning him in person. When he wasn't around, his mother knew, the neighbors gossiped about him constantly. When he was around, the children on the street weren't allowed on the property, as if the neighbors were afraid his thinking might be infectious.

"The internet is a beautiful place," Mason murmured.

He had never left New Orleans. He had lived in the same neighborhood in the same district in the same city his entire life. He had always had his family nearby to protect him. The internet wasn't a beautiful place. The internet was a dangerous place. His mother stayed up late into the night, sitting alone in the kitchen with the lamp lit, searching the news for stories about postcorporeals. Earlier that month a postcorporeal from Indianapolis had been infected with a virus that had damaged her programming so severely

that she had crashed and hadn't been able to be revived, effectively killing her. And only the week prior a postcorporeal from Baltimore had been attacked by hackers, had her memory looted for credit card information and social security numbers, had random sections of her data vandalized apparently just out of spite, and been left in the digital equivalent of a coma. While the year before in a highly publicized case a company in Phoenix that hosted postcorporeals from across the country had failed to maintain its facilities properly, not out of negligence but rather in a deliberate attempt to increase profits, regularly skipping the safety inspections standard to the industry, which had come to the attention of the public only after the servers at the data center had been fried by a power surge from a lightning strike, resulting in hundreds of postcorporeals vanishing from the world in a flash, in a disaster the magnitude of a collapsing hotel or a crashing plane, an event that never would have happened had the place been up to code.

She wouldn't have any way to watch over him anymore.

How long would he survive out there?

For Mardi Gras his family had a tradition of spending the day together, which was an important event every year but this year had taken on particular significance, because the operation was scheduled to take place the following morning. It was going to be her last chance to be with him. She tried to suppress her sense of grief to focus on making the day as perfect as possible. That was all she wanted, a perfect day, so that after losing him she could at least always remember that her last day with him had been special. She shook her head at his father and sent him back into the bedroom to change out of the tank top and cargo shorts he had picked out into something nicer. She made his brothers promise not to pick any fights with tourists. She loaded her purse with spray-on sunscreen and bottled waters.

And the day was perfect. His family looked beautiful, proud parents and polite children

dressed in fine clothing made by respected brands, and in the morning his family snagged prime spots for viewing the parades and saw floats so spectacular as to be truly among the best in living memory, and in the afternoon his family got ice cream cones piled high with generous scoops of butter pecan and rocky road and vanilla bean and blue moon and then strolled along the riverfront cracking jokes, and in the evening his family stumbled onto a live performance put on in a park by an unassuming band and heard a funk concert that wowed the crowd to such an extent that afterward members of the audience formed a line to shake hands with the musicians. And then after dusk his family set up on the patio of a cafe, splitting a platter of nachos and sipping from pints of ale, people-watching over the fence, and that was perfect too. The temperature was mild, the breeze was pleasant, and dazzling stars filled the sky above the street. The road was strewn with colorful debris. Metallic noisemakers, cracked to-go cups, a trampled bouquet, tangled strings of beads, fluorescent dildos, an acrylic bong. Revelers streamed past the patio, people grinning behind feathered masks and people primping rainbow wigs and people whose skin was painted with mesmerizing swirls and people in sequined outfits twirling jeweled canes that glittered under the streetlights and people breathing fire to the cheers of people riding by on unicycles and people embracing strangers and people chanting nonsense with friends and people in billowing capes skipping with each other down the street, and even in the midst of all of that pleasure and joy and happiness, Mason still seemed faintly bored. Eventually he took his phone out of his jacket, hunching over the screen, responding to messages, sending new messages, ignoring the carnival completely. He had only nibbled at the nachos. He had merely nipped at the ale. And at the concert he hadn't clapped between songs and instead of watching the performance had just fiddled with his phone, and along the riverfront he hadn't even wanted an ice cream cone and instead of watching the steamboats had just fiddled with his phone, and during the parades he hadn't

bothered to catch any of the throws and instead of watching the floats had just fiddled with his phone. The day had been perfect, and the day had been ruined anyway, because he had been too distracted to experience any of it. His mother leaned back in her chair with a frown. She had worried that she might get so sad tonight that she would cry, but all that worrying had been for nothing, because she wasn't sad. She was furious. He might as well have already been gone. He couldn't look away from that fucking screen.

She stood from the table so suddenly that her chair toppled over backward with a smack.

"You disgust me," she spat.

Mason glanced up with a startled look.

"I want no part of whatever type of life you plan to have after tomorrow," she said, walked out of the cafe, and drove home alone.

Back at the house she changed into baggy sweatpants and a shirt that had been washed and dried so many times that the fabric was soft and wispy, an outfit which generally gave her great pleasure to wear, but which of course now she was too angry to enjoy. She had meant what she had said. She hadn't planned to say it, but she didn't regret saying it, either. She was done with him. She was livid. She grabbed a bag of caramels, popped the cap from a stout, and sat down at the table in the kitchen with the lamp on to eat and drink and enjoy it, not just out of spite for him, but out of spite for all postcorporeality. She was still sitting there when headlights swung into the driveway and a key rattled in the door and in walked his father, who could see that she was in no mood to talk, so kissed her head, patted her shoulders, and then went into the bathroom to get ready for bed. Snoring soon filled the house, but she was too restless to lie down, too wired on beer and sugar, so she cleaned instead. She scrubbed the toilet, she scrubbed the tub, and she scrubbed the grime that had formed around the faucet of the sink, trying to avoid thinking about

him, which she couldn't, so eventually she gave up. She thought about him. She wandered the house in the glow of the streetlights coming through the windows, inspecting the contents of cabinet drawers and closet shelves, examining different mementos from his life. Here were the stuffed animals that he had tolerated sleeping with. Here were the action figures that he had endured playing with. Here were the hand casts that he had complained about posing for even after having finished posing. And, oh, here, this was the container full of messages he had written to her at school during lunch. She peeled the lid from the container with a sense of awe. When packing lunches, she had always slipped a note into each lunchbox. And at a certain age he had begun writing her back, shutting a reply into his lunchbox for her to find when she later opened his lunchbox to empty out the used baggies. His messages had been written on scraps torn from the corners of notebook paper, using whatever type of utensil he had favored at the time. Crayons, then colored pencils, eventually markers, and gel pens as a teenager. The messages had never said anything memorable, just remarks about his classes, or comments about his schoolmates, but she had loved those notes. None of his brothers had ever written her back.

She remembered now, that was the last thing he had said to her at the cafe before becoming engrossed in his screen. He had been explaining the logistics of the operation. He had smiled, "I'll message you after it's finished."

She dozed off on the couch at some point during the night and ended up with an arm and a leg dangling over the side and her face pressed into the crack between a pair of cushions. His father woke her just before leaving for work. Rain was drizzling. She brushed her teeth, tied her hair back, threw on some eyeliner, put on some lipstick, and got dressed in her uniform for the motel. By then the rain was a downpour. The wipers on her car needed to be replaced, and her breath was fogging the windows, so she could

hardly see as she drove. She felt terrible. Mason would be at the clinic by now. Nobody had gone with him. She should have kept her mouth shut the night before. She had just been so angry, but even if his choice was abominable, he was still her son. The guilt was awful. The wipers thocked back and forth. She swiped at the fog with the cuff of a sleeve. Her pulse sped up as she made the decision. She had to go. She was terrified by the thought of being there for the transition, the moment when his body would be suddenly empty, the moment when his mind would be suddenly gone, but she needed to hold him one last time before she lost him. She drove past the motel and merged onto the highway.

The clinic was locked. After buzzing her in, the receptionist asked for her identification and checked a list for her name and then led her down an empty hall into the operating room, where he had already been sedated. Tears welled in her eyes. The procedure was underway. She wouldn't have a chance to say goodbye. A machine enclosed his head completely, with the rest of his body extending out of the machine onto a gurney. His palms were crossed over his chest. A neon pink plastic wristband identified him for the operators. Aside from a pair of plain white boxers, he was naked. Seeing him in there like that was so upsetting that she almost turned to leave, but instead she wiped the tears from her eyes and forced herself to take a seat on the stool next to the gurney. She leaned her umbrella against the wall, she set her purse on the floor, and then she held his hands in her hands. The operators nodded at her, and then went back to work, adjusting dials and skimming scans. There was nothing to do but wait, and the wait was terrible. The constant feeling of dread that she had been living with since his announcement was so much worse than ever before. Rain pelted the roof. Indicator lights blinked. The operators murmured to each other. She kept wondering whether the moment had passed, waiting for some sign that the transition had occurred, but there was no way of telling. Her muscles were tensed. Her teeth were clenched. And her dread just kept building.

She was bracing for the moment of the transition, squeezing his hands with a tight grip, breathing so fast that she was slightly dizzy, staring at his body, when she became aware of a faint beeping coming from a monitor on the machine. The sound made her think of her phone, tucked into the breast pocket of her uniform with the volume on high. She actually would know when the transition had occurred, she realized. When he messaged her, her phone would chime. She glanced down at her uniform, looking at the bulge her phone made in the pocket, and when she did, the strangest thing happened. She felt a burst of joy. Excitement so intense that a shiver passed through her. This sense that she wasn't about to lose him forever, but instead was finally about to meet him, truly meet him, for the first time. The feeling confused her, but the longer that she stared at the pocket expecting her phone to chime at any moment, the stronger that the feeling grew, until she was nearly overcome with anticipation. His hands were still warm, but whether the life had left his body yet didn't matter. She felt certain of that suddenly. It wasn't him. It never had been.

About The Author

Matthew Baker is the author of the graphic novel *The Sentence*, the story collections *Why Visit America* and *Hybrid Creatures*, and the children's novel *Key Of X*. Digital experiments include the temporal fiction "Ephemeral," the interlinked novel *Untold*, the randomized novel *Verses*, and the intentionally posthumous *Afterthought*.

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